

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Turning Over Tables:
A Lenten Call for Disrupting Power
Cultivate*

April 6th, 2025



540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in- Residence*

Improvisation on MERLE'S TUNE and HYMN TO JOY
A Window To The Past (John Williams, arr. C. Bull)
Meditation on ATTENDE DOMINE
O Mensch, Bewein Dein Sünde Groß (Johann Sebastian Bach)
Meditation on LONESOME VALLEY

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Ruthie Condren

Generously, Lavishly, Abundantly.
God spreads seeds of holy possibility far and wide.
Who will nurture their potential?
Who will tend their growth?

The Spirit of Life cries out for cooperation
so that love may blossom,
that justice may be a bountiful crop,
and that courage may grow unencumbered.

Let not the gifts of God be wasted
but the harvest be plenty.
Let Divine Life flourish among us
and may all who long for God
join the labors of liberation.
[enfleshed]

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Lenten Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering.**

Celebrate Our Maker's Glory

HYMN TO JOY

Celebrate our Maker's glory, shining brightly everywhere;
all the world is charged with grandeur, calling for our loving care.
Starry skies and golden meadows, soaring eagles, leaping deer,
clapping trees and singing mountains lift our hearts with hope and cheer.

Love Divine is like a fountain, gushing forth unending streams,
filling earth with lavish blessings, stirring everyone to dream.
Gladly sharing gifts with others, we fulfill our sacred call,
swinging wide the doors of freedom, bringing Good News unto all.

Feel the Holy Spirit's power, deep within us and above,
helping us discern our mission, guiding everyone to love.
Joining hands for peace and justice, we will work so all are free,
partners in the new creation, making dreams reality.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

O God, in this, our gathering time,
may our hearts be open to the stirring
of holiness.

May it cause us to know grace
in those places where
seeds of judgment are sown.

May it allow us to soothe our pain-filled
memories with peace.

May it help us to experience joy
in the divine presence
of all our gathered siblings.

As we open our hearts to the stirring of holiness
that helps us know we truly belong,
may we sense the humble power of your grace and love
in this place today.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

***Introit**

"No nos moverán" Spiritual and Labor Movement March
Cathedral Choir

"We Shall not be moved! Just like a tree that's planted by the water, we shall not be moved!"

***The Lord's Prayer**

Ruthie Condren

O, Birther of the Cosmos, focus your light within us --
make it useful.
Create your reign of unity now
Your one desire then acts with ours,
As in all light,
So in all forms.
Grant us what we need each day in bread and insight:
Loose the cords of mistakes binding us,
As we release the strands we hold of others guilt.
Don't let surface things delude us,
But free us from what holds us back.

From you is born all ruling will,
The power and the life to do,
The song that beautifies all,
From age to age it renews.
We affirm this with our whole being.

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Taking a moment to sense our oneness,
our roots push far into the soil
and we find ourselves deeply connected
with all that is and was and yet shall be.

May our experience of what we do here this day,
so affect us, that we leave from this place
in awe of the deepest connections we have cultivated.

From the depths of our common hope,
may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition
from the Gospel of Mark

Ruthie Condren & Rev. Tanaka Pack

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Gracious God, Source of all Blessings,
You have been extravagant in your generosity.
You have planted within us the seeds of hope.
You have nurtured within us the saplings of faith.
You have harvested the fruits of your creation and
spread before us the feast of all possibility.

Words cannot express the gratitude with which
we come before you.

May we embody our thanks with extravagant generosity.
May we offer our lives to you in acts of compassion for one another.
May we walk gently upon the earth, ever mindful of your gifts
of Breath, of Love, of Life itself. [Anne G. Cohen]
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem.

“Chorale” from *Symphony For Voices 1*

DAVID HARRIS

*“The trees encountered on a country stroll reveal a lot about a country’s soul.
A culture is no better than its woods.” W. H. Auden
“We are all systems through which matter is continually passing.” ~William Bateson*

“The best time to plant a tree is twenty years ago. The second best time is now.” ~Chinese proverb

Sermon

Cultivate

Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

In this place, we believe in a world made new,
where mourning is turned into dancing,
and souls are set free.

*We believe in a world where all are heard
and rivers flow where each may drink,
a world where the harvest becomes
a banquet for all.*

The God of all creation has given us
a world of beauty.
God has given us a place of plenty
where no one needs to hunger...
if we learn to share.

This morning we ask that our hearts may be opened
in order that we might understand compassion.
We ask that our minds will be opened
so that we may receive the courage
to count the cost.

*We ask for the strength to let go of all that binds us
to our privilege, our wealth, and our possessions.*

And we ask, for God to guide us as we work
to bring about God’s dream for the world,
a world where we all are part of one community,
a community filled with justice and peace.

We take this bread as Jesus did when he gathered with those he loved.
We break it and bless it and share it.

We take this cup as Jesus did with his friends.
We pour it and bless it and share it.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"For Good" from Wicked"
Tiffany Ho and Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Soloists*

STEPHEN SCHWARTZ

***Lenten Doxology**

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost. Amen.

***Prayer of Offering**

Ruthie Condren

Holy One, you have provided us with all we need to to cultivate life and love in community. Even under harsh conditions, you come to us with gifts of care, compassion, and courage, promising to multiply them among willing hearts.

We now bring our offerings in gratitude, as we pray that we may be faithful to one another and loyal to the calling of these blessed, belonging days.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

Through hardship and trials against the odds,
we are beginning to trust that the world
can be a brave place for us,
and we have every right to be here.

We have made parents of our instincts,
intuitions, and dreaming;
we have allowed love into where it
had never before been received;
we have grown life where once
it was barren.

Our gifts, and our goodness given,
is a boon for us all.
With just a few found and trustworthy seeds,
together we are nurturing the greatest harvest
there is: a life of belonging for all of us,
and for all who are yet to come.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“Lao Rahal Soti” SAMIH CHOUKEIR, arr. SHIREEN ABU-KHADER
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Soloist*

*“If my voice departs, your voices will not. I look unto tomorrow and my heart is with you.
If the singer departs, the song will remain, bringing together the broken hearts.”*

*Hymn for the Journey

As Grain on Scattered Hillsides

MERLE’S TUNE

As grain on scattered hillsides, when gathered, makes one bread,
God, gather all your people as one in Christ our head.
We come from many places, and we are not the same,
Yet your strong love has called us to meet in your name.

A grain of wheat is fruitless until in earth it lies;
Then, dying to its old life, it bears and multiplies.
So may we die to hatred, to all our hurtful ways,
Reborn to common living, to love, to work, to praise.

Like yeast that brings new ferment so lifeless dough may rise,
Your Spirit is the leaven of life that satisfies.
As salt enhances flavor, enriches, and preserves,
May earth rejoice to savor a church that heals and serves.

O Christ, the new creation; O Spirit, filled with peace,
Come now and move among us; make us a sign of love.
Come, knead and blend each texture with strong and gentle hands,
That we may be one body, one loaf in many lands.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Gigue (Elizabeth Turner)

Inside The Music

“This week we celebrated Cesar Chavez day and the work of the Labor Movement and everyone who has mobilized across this nation’s history to demand equity for all people. The profound energy that it takes to cultivate a robust, unified response to concentrated power boggles my mind. Such movements are always aided by the music and art that regularly infuse humanity into their efforts. “No nos moverán” is one of the tunes. The Farm Workers borrowed it from the Civil Rights Movement. Once they added a new text, it became a rallying cry, a repeatable moment for the breaking of new ground in people’s minds and souls. We can draw on their energy as we hear it in our space this week. I wrote

"Symphony For Voices 1" last year as a way of dedicating our Cathedral Gardens and Urban Farm. The movement we'll sing today, "Chorale," centers on why we cultivate, and who we are in the midst of cultivation. It opens with Auden's reflection on the central importance of forests to the soul of a people. The music flows between a chorale setting of Auden's words, and moments of reflection. During those moments, the ensemble creates sonic colors that articulate high harmonic sounds in different ways. As they sing these varied colors, I sing a melody in overtones that will sound like a haunting whistle if you're not used to hearing it. The overtone tune echoes the folk-like melodies found in the 19th century symphonists like Beethoven and Schubert when they referenced woodlands. These moments of pause between the text are there to give space for the text to deepen into our minds, and to recall the spaciousness that forests provide us. The middle section uses words by William Bateson. He is the biologist who first coined the term "genetics." He noticed that we all think we are matter, that is, something solid that stands alone in the world. Yet, in reality, we are simply systems through which matter passes. This perspective feels essential as we consider cultivation. In order to create something, we must agree to the destructive power of change and the free flow of energy. Our lives have to disorder as we reorder ourselves to cultivation. When we hold to ourselves as unchanging, we are stuck and can not cultivate newness. Musically, the choir sings in microtonal scales, allowing for the "matter" of the music to pass into our ears in new ways. It ends with a return of the opening music and a famous Chinese proverb reminding us that newness is a Now prospect. I like "For Good" for this week, as it illuminates the outcome of change. We are treated to the reality that no outcome is predictable. We don't begin because we know what will happen. We begin because we know no other way. What happens, and what meaning we glean from it, is ours to discover in time. This week begins Arab American Heritage Month. We sing "Lao Rahal Soti," written by Palestinian composer Samih Choukeir to honor the gifts of their cultures. It is a reminder that what we cultivate lives on beyond our time here. In the same way, we have songs in us that those who came before us sang in our ears. They are the vibrations of our consciousness that motivate us to build together in ways that ensure equity and justice not only for ourselves, but for those who will come after us." -Dr. David Harris